

**INCLUDING EVERYONE**
Shashi Panja (fifth from left) hands out certificates and ID cards to transgender persons to help them apply for government jobs at a ceremony in Kolkata, Mar. 1

minister of women and child development and social welfare to head it. The success and international recognition of Kanyashree—it won the United Nations public service award—has worked to both Mamata and Shashi's credit. The benefits from Kanyashree have now been extended to cover female college and university students.

Mamata's many schemes for women have their political detractors, not least the state BJP. Says BJP MLA Agnimitra Paul: "I recognise and respect her (Mamata's) struggle, which is another form of empowerment. But her women's schemes are vote-catching devices. Had Kanyashree served its purpose, we wouldn't have had four lakh students dropping out of the board examination."

Industry and commerce, Shashi's newest charge, is not only a high-profile department, it is also an area in which Bengal lags behind. Shashi is now trying to increase Bengal's visibility vis-à-vis industry and is working on a perception change. "It's sad that Tata Nano stopped production at Sanand in Gujarat, but we still continue to talk about the exit from Singur. I wonder why people don't talk about the end of bandh culture or zero man-days lost," she once said. At a gathering of industrialists in September, she asked them to believe in the Trinamool government and pointed to the state's "political and financial stability".

**MAMATA UNDERSTANDS THE PULSE OF WOMEN BETTER THAN ANY OTHER POLITICIAN, SAYS CHANDRIMA BHATTACHARYA**

Another sector close to Mamata's heart is women's self-help groups. Former actress Birbaha Hansda was made MoS for the department of self help groups after she became a first-time MLA in 2021. Aware of Birbaha's Santhal background and the ease with which she can mingle with women at the grassroots, Mamata handpicked her for the job. "I remember she told me distinctly after I took oath that I should always be with women. I am grateful that she has trusted me with this department, which throws up so much opportunity to work for women," says Birbaha. The fight against patriarchy, she says, may seem endless, but adds that having women ministers will go a long way in breaking the mindset about such jobs being male bastions.

Then there's the famed personal touch of Mamata—one of her chief political assets—that is attested to by both Shashi and Chandrima. Shashi is amazed by how the CM remembers every little thing and finds an occasion to give her credit in public. "I feel honoured and empowered when Didi says 'my minister'. It's nice to hear people say 'she's the first lady minister of industry and commerce', but whatever responsibility Didi gives is precious," says Shashi.

Chandrima talks about both a stern and indulgent Mamata. "Like a mother, Didi will scold you, but before you start to sulk, she'll call you up on different things to help you bounce back," she says. Mamata, she says, understands the pulse of women better than any other politician. During the high-octane 2021 assembly polls, Mamata presented herself as a woman fighting misogyny, muscle power and a macho Hindutva. TMC secured 50 per cent of the female vote as against 37 per cent obtained by the BJP. "She showed her gratefulness by having 20 per cent women in her cabinet. Our prime minister has 15 per cent women in his," says Chandrima.

The BJP, however, is unimpressed by this narrative. BJP MLA Srirupa Mitra Chaudhury says, "While it's commendable that women are appointed to important positions, one must assess if they have been given the necessary resources and support to excel in their roles. Women deserve more than tokenism in politics."

Ask Chandrima, and she will tell you that Mamata is always attentive to the needs of women around her. "She's even attentive to who's wearing what, without being judgemental. When Mimi Chakraborty and Nusrat Jahan first attended Parliament in trousers, there was lot of trolling, but Mamata stood by them for being smartly dressed," she says.

Women, they say, hold up half the sky. In West Bengal, Mamata and her band of seven women ministers are doing a fine job of holding the reins of their party and the state. ■